MASTERCLASS 1 · 20 NOVEMBER 2026

Know enough.

The heart of the business, and when to bring someone in.

Format	Live masterclass, up to 90 minutes including questions
Audience	Founders House members. No course needed beforehand
Presenter	Mila Milićević · NexaStrategic
Deck	27 slides, plus the Know Enough Map handout

DRAFT · PLAN AND SCRIPT

1. The idea

You don't need to be the operator. You need to know enough to know when. A founder's job isn't operations. But every founder needs a base knowledge of each part of operations: enough to recognise what good enough looks like at their size, to spot when a part has outgrown them, to know who to bring in, and to ask that person one precise question.

Where Mila stands. A good operator is a Swiss Army knife: a bit of everything, and exactly where their limits are. That's why Mila can teach this. It isn't what founders are asked to become. They get the judgement, not the job.

What founders leave with. A filled-in Know Enough Map scored red, amber and green, one red picked, and a four-part brief ready to send to the right person that week.

In scope	Out of scope
Good enough at your size, for each panel	Turning founders into operations managers
The triggers for bringing someone in	How to run each panel (that's Operations Fundamentals)
Who to bring in: the ladder from smallest to most senior	Legal, tax or financial advice, or ruling on anyone's situation
How to brief a specialist precisely	Founder behaviour and bottlenecks (David's territory)
Being a better client	Criticising professionals; statistics

Run sheet

Time	Part	Slides	Goal
0–15	1. Why knowing enough matters	1–8	Heart, ball, knife, then the flip: you don’t need to be the operator
15–60	2. Four panels	9–20	Finance, legal, people, commercial: good enough, triggers, who, the question, watch for
60–75	3. The brief	21–23	The four-part brief, then a live rewrite
75–80	4. This week	24–26	Score, pick one red, write the brief, send it
80–90	Questions	27	Open floor

Guardrails

The not-advice line is said once, early (slide 6). Every panel ends with when to bring someone in, never “you can skip this”. The language is “be a better client” and “buy precisely”, never “swindled”: there may be lawyers, accountants and sponsors in the room. One line about the course at the end, and no pitch for operations support. The ladders and examples are general and UK-based; a professional confirms specifics. Fictional examples are labelled.

2. Why this angle

What's on the market. Most operations masterclasses for founders sell "get the founder out of the way" (UCLA Anderson's Founder Bottleneck, TUM's Scale Yourself, Indy Chamber's systems and delegation session). Others teach values-to-process frameworks (EOS's Visionary and Integrator, operating-principles content from VC firms such as Bain Capital Ventures, SOP content from lean practitioners). Ritz-Carlton's Gold Standards is the classic case, and it's heavily used.

The gap. I didn't find anyone teaching founders the operating literacy to know when to bring someone in and how to brief them. Specialists have little reason to teach it, and founder coaches usually don't know every panel. This is a gap in what a few searches found, not proof nobody does it.

How it was tested. I ran the idea past a council of four advisory lenses (an operator, a sceptic, a strategist and a founder in the audience). All four independently put the Swiss Army knife idea ahead of a principles-to-SOPs framework. They agreed on four panels live and four on the map, a practical take-home, "oversold" rather than "swindled", and no pitch. Your refinement, that founders shouldn't become the ops person, sharpened it further.

Why it suits the room and beyond. It stands alone for founders who haven't taken the course, and it's clearly separate from David's work: his is the founder, this is what the business needs and who provides it. It can become a paid masterclass with a fuller map, question bank and worked examples, and travels to accelerators and a US version.

3. Slide by slide

For each slide: what's on it, the **message** (the one thing it says), the **goal** (what it should do to the room), and the script. The script is a starting point to say in your own words. *[Brackets]* mark what you need to add.

Part 1 · Why knowing enough matters (15 minutes)

1
COVER

Founders House · Masterclass · 20 November · Know enough. · The heart of the business, and when to bring someone in. · Mila Milićević · NexaStrategic

Message Operations, from a founder's seat, without becoming the ops person.

Goal Set the frame and get the map in their hands.

> Up to 90 minutes including questions. Part 1, why knowing enough matters (15 min). Part 2, four panels (45). Part 3, the brief (15). Part 4, this week (5). Questions (10). Hand out the Know Enough Map before you start: founders fill it in as you go.

2
HEART

Every business has a heart · Operations. · It keeps everything else alive.

Message Operations is the heart: it keeps everything else alive.

Goal Keep your signature idea, in one minute. Frame, not content.

> You are the brain of your business: the ideas, the decisions, the direction. Your customers see the body: the product, the service, the brand. Operations is the heart. It keeps everything else alive: money moving, people paid, contracts honoured, deadlines met. When it works, nobody notices. When it doesn't, everything else struggles. Keep this to a minute; it's the frame, not the content.

3
BALL

And it's one thing · One ball. Eight panels. · Process · People · Commercial · Finance Legal · Compliance · Governance · Risk

Message Operations is one thing with eight panels.

Goal Give them the whole picture once, from a founder's seat.

> I think of operations as a beach ball. Eight panels, one ball. Process, people, commercial, finance, legal, compliance, governance, risk. Bigger companies cut it into legal ops, fin ops, rev ops, and each team sees only its own colour. I don't. Everything touches everything: a new client is a contract, an invoice, a hire and a risk at once. Tonight we look at the panels from a founder's seat: not how to run them, but how to know when one needs someone.

4 KNIFE

What I do · A good operator is a Swiss Army knife. · A bit of everything. And exactly where my limits are.

Message This is how I work: a bit of everything, and I know my limits.

Goal Your credibility, said as how you work, not as a lecture.

> This is how I work. I know a bit about every panel: enough to spot a problem, enough to know what good looks like. And I know exactly where I stop. When I go to a lawyer, I don't ask them to tell me everything; I ask one question. When someone tells me I need a CFO, I know whether I actually need an accountant. Knowing the edges is the skill. Say this plainly, as how you work, not as advice.

5 FLIP

You don't need to be the operator. You need to know enough to know when.

Message You don't need to be the operator. You need to know enough to know when.

Goal The thesis. Take the pressure off founders, then give them the job.

> Pause. This is the idea of the session. Your job as a founder isn't to become the operations person. It's to know enough about each part of the business to recognise when it needs someone, who that someone is, and what to ask them. That's what tonight gives you.

6 ADVICE

Tonight · Judgement, not advice. · How to recognise what you need and brief the right person. Nothing tonight is legal, tax or financial advice.

Message Tonight is judgement, not advice.

Goal Draw the line once, early, then move on.

> Say this once, early, and move on. I have a law degree and I've run operations for a lot of businesses, but tonight is about judgement: recognising what you need and who to ask. When it matters, the answer is always a qualified professional. My aim is that you get more from them.

7 STORY

A story · "You need a CFO." · What they needed was an accountant.

Message Founders get sold more than they need because they don't know enough to ask.

Goal Make it real and a little personal. Recognition, not blame.

> *[Your story: one real, anonymised example where a business was told it needed more than it did, or bought the wrong specialist. No names, nothing that identifies the business.]* Fallback (fictional): a 12-person business is told it needs a fractional CFO for its finances. What it actually needs is monthly accounts and a three-month cash view, which a good accountant does for a fraction of the cost. Nobody was dishonest; the founder just didn't know enough to ask the right question. Show of hands: who has bought help and wasn't quite sure what they were paying for?

8
BUYS

What knowing enough buys you · You spot it early. · You call the right person. · You ask one precise question. · You pay for what you need.

Message Knowing enough saves time and money, and makes you a better client.

Goal Name the payoff before the content.

> Four things. You spot a problem while it's small. You call the right kind of person, not the most senior one. You ask a precise question, so you get a precise answer. And you pay for what you need, not for everything a specialist could do. None of this is about distrusting professionals. It's about being a better client.

Part 2 · Four panels (45 minutes)

9
P2

Part 2 · Four panels · Good enough, and when to bring someone in.

Message Four panels, ten minutes each.

Goal Signal the main part. Set the pace.

> Part 2, about 45 minutes. Four panels founders most often over-buy or under-buy: finance, legal, people, commercial. About ten minutes each. The other four are on your map.

10
LENS

For every panel · Good enough · Bring someone in when · Who · The question to ask · Watch for

Message Every panel gets the same five things.

Goal Give them the structure of the map so they can fill it in.

> Every panel gets the same five things, and they match the columns on your map. What good enough looks like at your size. The signs it's time to bring someone in. Who that is, from the smallest step up. The one question to take them. And what to watch for: the sign you're being offered more than you need. Fill in your row as we go, and give yourself red, amber or green.

11
FINANCE

Panel 1 of 4 · Finance · Good enough · Books up to date every month. · Cash known three months ahead. · Tax deadlines in the diary. · Bring someone in when · You can't say what cash you'll have. · You're raising money. · Tax gets complicated.

Message Clean books and a cash view are good enough for most; know the signs you've outgrown them.

Goal Make 'good enough' concrete for finance.

> Good enough: the books are up to date every month, you know what cash you'll have three months out, and every tax deadline is in a diary someone owns. Bring someone in when you can't answer the cash question, when you're raising money, or when tax gets complicated: VAT, payroll, selling or hiring in another country.

12

FINANCE WHO

Finance · Who, and what to ask · Bookkeeper · Accountant · Finance director, part-time · CFO · “Can you give us monthly management accounts and a three-month cash view, for a fixed fee?” · Watch for: · Strategy and fundraising support, when you need clean books.

Message Know the finance ladder: most of you need the first two rungs.

Goal The accountant-not-CFO moment. Model a precise brief.

> The ladder: a bookkeeper keeps the books. An accountant prepares accounts and tax, and can usually do management accounts. A part-time finance director builds forecasts and reporting. A CFO is strategy, fundraising and a finance team. Most businesses at this stage need the first two, done well. *[Your example, if you have one.]* The question: read it out. Notice what makes it good: it names the deliverable, the scope and the price. Watch for: Strategy and fundraising support, when you need clean books. Score your row: red, amber or green.

13

LEGAL

Panel 2 of 4 · Legal · Good enough · A founders’ agreement. · Standard customer terms. · The company owns its IP. · Bring someone in when · You don’t understand what you’re signing. · Investment, or a dispute. · Another country.

Message Three documents and reading what you sign are the basics.

Goal Make ‘good enough’ concrete for legal.

> Good enough: a founders’ or shareholders’ agreement, standard terms you use with customers, and the company, not individuals, owning the work and the IP. And you’ve read what you’ve signed. Bring someone in when you don’t understand a contract you’re about to sign, when you’re raising investment or in a dispute, or when you’re hiring or selling in another country.

14

LEGAL WHO

Legal · Who, and what to ask · Templates · Solicitor, one question · Specialist · In-house counsel · “Please review clauses 8 and 12 for our liability and exit. We don’t need a full review.” · Watch for: · A full review or a retainer, when you need one clause answered.

Message Ask a lawyer one question, not ‘tell me everything’.

Goal Show how to brief a lawyer. Not legal advice.

> The ladder: good templates for the routine. A solicitor for one specific question. A specialist (employment, IP, corporate) when the question is in their area. In-house counsel much later. The question on the slide is the habit: point them at the clauses and the risk you care about. Not legal advice; the point is how you brief. The question: read it out. Notice what makes it good: it names the deliverable, the scope and the price. Watch for: A full review or a retainer, when you need one clause answered. Score your row: red, amber or green.

15
PEOPLE

Panel 3 of 4 · People · Good enough · Contracts and right-to-work checks. · Payroll and pensions running. · Everyone knows their role. · Bring someone in when · The first performance problem. · Someone has to leave. · Hiring abroad.

Message Contracts, payroll and clear roles; the first hard conversation is the trigger.

Goal Make ‘good enough’ concrete for people.

> Good enough: written contracts and right-to-work checks for everyone, payroll and workplace pensions running, and everyone knows what their role is and who they report to. UK basics; check the specifics with a professional. Bring someone in at the first performance problem, the first time someone has to leave, or when you hire outside the UK. These are the moments where getting the process wrong costs most.

16
PEOPLE WHO

People · Who, and what to ask · Payroll provider · HR adviser · Employment solicitor · Head of people · “We have a performance issue. What fair process do we follow, and what do we write down?” · Watch for: · A full HR system and policy library at ten people.

Message Get process help before you need a solicitor.

Goal Model the question; flag the over-built HR stack.

> The ladder: a payroll provider. An HR adviser or helpline for process questions. An employment solicitor when there’s a dispute or real risk. A head of people when you’re big enough to need one. *[Your example.]* The question: read it out. Notice what makes it good: it names the deliverable, the scope and the price. Watch for: A full HR system and policy library at ten people. Score your row: red, amber or green.

17
COMMERCIAL

Panel 4 of 4 · Commercial · Good enough · Margin known on what you sell. · Payment terms in writing. · A pipeline you can see. · Bring someone in when · Only you can sell. · You can’t forecast next quarter. · The CRM is a graveyard.

Message Know your margin, your terms and your pipeline.

Goal Make ‘good enough’ concrete for commercial.

> Good enough: you know the margin on each thing you sell, your payment terms are written down and in every contract, and you can see your pipeline without asking someone. Bring someone in when only you can sell, when you can’t forecast next quarter, or when the CRM is full of deals nobody believes.

18

COMMERCIAL WHO

Commercial · Who, and what to ask · Freelancer · Rev ops specialist · Sales lead · Head of revenue · “Set up our pipeline so we can see deals by stage and forecast next quarter. Nothing more.” · Watch for: · A full rev ops stack before you have a repeatable sale.

Message Rev ops is useful once there’s a repeatable sale to systemise.

Goal Respect the specialism; warn against buying the stack too early.

> The ladder: a freelancer to set up a simple CRM and pipeline. A rev ops specialist once you have a repeatable sale to systemise. A sales lead. A head of revenue much later. Rev ops is real and useful; the mistake is buying the whole stack before there’s a process to put in it. The question: read it out. Notice what makes it good: it names the deliverable, the scope and the price. Watch for: A full rev ops stack before you have a repeatable sale. Score your row: red, amber or green.

19

OTHER

The other four · Process · Compliance · Governance · Risk · Same five things. They’re on your map.

Message The other four work the same way, and they’re on the map.

Goal Keep the session honest about what fits in 90 minutes.

> No time to do all eight properly tonight, so the other four are on the map with the same five columns filled in. Process: when the same mistake keeps happening. Compliance: when you’re in a regulated sector, hold sensitive data or sell abroad. Governance: when outside investors or a board arrive. Risk: when you depend on one client or one person. Do them at home.

20

OPS

And the last one · When nobody holds the whole ball. · Things fall between the panels, and you’re the only one who sees all eight. That’s when you bring in an operations person.

Message When nobody holds the whole ball, bring in an operations person.

Goal The final trigger. Neutral and short, never a pitch.

> The last trigger isn’t a panel; it’s the ball. When things start falling between panels, a contract nobody invoiced, a hire nobody set up payroll for, and you’re the only person who sees all eight, that’s the moment to bring in someone whose job is operations. That might be an operations manager, an ops-minded hire, or outside support. Keep this neutral and short: it’s a trigger, not a pitch.

Part 3 · The brief (15 minutes)

21

P3

Part 3 · The brief · Ask one precise question.

Message Knowing who to call is half of it.

Goal Move from knowing to asking.

> Part 3, about 15 minutes. Knowing who to call is half of it. The other half is what you say when you call.

22
BRIEF

Not this · “Can you have a look at our contracts?” · This · The problem, in one line. · The decision I need. · What’s out of scope. · A fee cap, and by when.

Message A good brief has four parts: problem, decision, scope, fee cap.

Goal Give them a tool they’ll use next week.

> A vague brief gets a big answer and a big bill. A good brief has four parts. The problem in one line. The decision you need to make with their answer. What you are not asking for. A fee cap and a deadline. This is the back of your map. Professionals generally prefer a clear brief: it makes their job easier too.

23
REWRITE

Your turn · “We need some help with HR.” · Rewrite it. Problem, decision, scope, fee cap.

Message You can do this in two minutes.

Goal Practice in the room. Improve briefs, don’t rule on situations.

> Live exercise, about 10 minutes. Read the bad brief. Ask the room to rewrite it using the four parts, in pairs or on their own. Take two or three rewrites and improve one together. A strong answer: “One of our team is consistently missing deadlines. We need to know the fair process to follow before we decide whether to start it. We don’t need policies or a handbook. Fixed fee, answer by Friday.” Volunteers can use a real brief instead, anonymised; don’t rule on their situation, just improve the brief.

Part 4 · This week (5 minutes)

24
THISWEEK

This week · Score your map. · Pick one red. · Write the brief. · Send it.

Message Score, pick one red, write the brief, send it.

Goal Turn the session into one action.

> Part 4, about 5 minutes. Score every row red, amber or green. Pick one red. Write the brief for it using the back of the map. Send it this week. One red fixed properly is worth more than eight half-looked at.

25
CLOSE

Know enough to know when.

Message Know enough to know when.

Goal The line they repeat afterwards.

> The close. You don’t need to be the operator. You need to know enough to know when to bring one in, who to bring in, and what to ask. Read it, and stop.

26
NEXT

Where to go next · Operations Fundamentals. · The whole ball, one panel at a time. Start with OF101.

Message If you want more than enough, the course takes the whole ball.

Goal One clear next step, one line.

> One line, then stop. If you want to go further than knowing enough, Operations Fundamentals takes the ball one panel at a time, starting with OF101. *[Add how founders join.]*

Questions (10 minutes)

27
QUESTIONS

Questions · Questions. · Mila Milićević · NexaStrategic

Message Open floor.

Goal Hear which panels came up red: material for the next masterclass.

> About 10 minutes. If questions are slow to start, ask: which panel did you score red?

4. Before the day

1. **Your story** (slide 7): one real, anonymised time a business was sold more than it needed. The fallback is fictional and labelled.
2. **One example per panel** if you have them (slides 12, 14, 16, 18).
3. **Have a professional sense-check the map**: an accountant for the finance row and a solicitor for legal and people.
4. **Print the Know Enough Map**, one per founder (separate PDF).
5. **How founders join the course** (slide 26).

Sources

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- NIST Baldrige blog on Ritz-Carlton's Gold Standards · nist.gov
- Allison Pickens, Why operations is the core · allisonpickens.substack.com

Several pages were seen only as search listings; the luma.com and UCLA pages were blocked by the session's network settings.

NexaStrategic · Draft. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.